Grad School Applications

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Bocconi & INSPIRE LEAP

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These slides are based on a presentation by Zahra Thabet and Gabriel Sekeres at SIEPR (with additions from Alvise, Bhavya, Daniel, and Luca), and on Irene Solmone's LEAP coffee slides.

The application calendar



Start now
GRE + letters
School List
(First drafts)

Build
Get feedback
(Open portals)

Tailor
Adapt materials
Track letters
Apply for fee waivers

Submit
Earliest US, LSE and funding deadlines

Continue
Later apps
Potential Waitlists

Plan around your earliest deadline.

Many continental European programs may give you more time; check program and funding deadlines individually.

As things stand in September

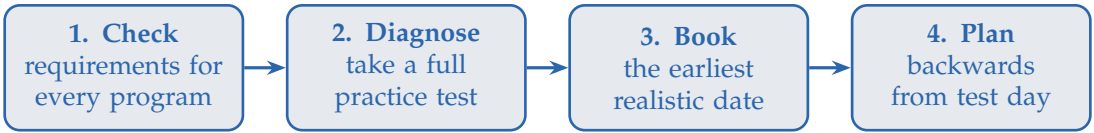
1. Make the GRE the priority

If you have not taken it yet:

- Take a diagnostic
- Book a September test date
- Protect time to prepare
- Leave room for a retake

2. Contact three recommenders
3. Build your initial school list
4. Draft your CV and statement
5. Choose your writing sample
6. Check English requirements (TOEFL/IELTS)

GRE: what to do this week



September	First attempt if you have not taken it yet
October	Retake if needed; keep preparing materials in parallel

Do not wait until you feel fully prepared before booking.

GRE: the essentials

- Required by almost all Economics PhD programs
- Available in person or at home
- 2 Quant, 2 Verbal, 1 Writing task
- About 2 hours in total
- Retake after 21 days, up to 5 times per year
- Scores arrive about 8–10 days later

Timing matters

Book early enough to preserve the option to retake.

Preparing for the GRE

1. **Diagnose:** take a free ETS PowerPrep test
2. **Learn + drill: GregMat + PrepSwift** — cheap and very good
3. **Add volume:** Manhattan Prep's 5 lb. Book
4. **Alternative platform:** Magoosh

Review every mistake; do not just count questions.

Finish with timed, full-length practice.

In person or online?

In person

Pros

- Lower technical risk
- Paper and pencil for scratch work

Cons

- Travel to a test centre
- Potentially fewer convenient slots

Online

Pros

- Flexible scheduling
- No travel

Cons

- Strict equipment and room setup
- Whiteboard or erasable sheet; no paper
- Live remote proctoring

Choose the setting in which you will be calmer.

Where to apply?

- Location: US vs Europe $\rightarrow$ slightly different processes, different periods of application, some different requirements
- Fields: try understanding what university/program fits you research interest broadly, not because of one/two specific faculty members. Ranking matters, but the fit does even more
- Consider Public Policy and Business Schools ($) programs
- Try to get a sense of the funding opportunities
- Organize in buckets: Reach, Target, Safety (be cautious with expectations!)

Key points: talk to your PI/PhD mentors/friends, and apply as widely as possible (given financial and time constraints)

Letters: ask early and make it easy

Choose three people who…

- Know your research work well
- Can describe how you think and work
- Provide complementary evidence

Ask directly: “Would you be comfortable writing me a strong letter?”

Give them one clear package

- CV and transcript
- Draft statement of purpose
- Short summary of your research work
- Program tracker with links and deadlines
- Your earliest deadline, clearly highlighted

Fellowships: search broadly and apply early

Start with these

- UniCredit Foundation
  Economics PhD; deadline 2 Nov 2026
- Rhodes Scholarship
  University of Oxford; early deadline
- Knight-Hennessy Scholars
  Stanford graduate programs

Search systematically

"[country of origin] + national bank + economics PhD fellowship"

"[undergraduate institution] + graduate fellowships for undergraduates"

Check citizenship, degree, destination, and internal nomination rules.

Application materials: tell one coherent story

The usual package

- Statement of purpose
- 500-word diversity statement
- Writing sample
- Resume / CV
- Miscellaneous requested writing (e.g. LSE)

The reader should quickly see

What you have done, what you want to study, and why you are ready.

Different documents, one consistent research narrative.

Statement of purpose: DOs

My favorite structure:

1. **Start with the questions** you want to study (research field, research ideas, current projects/proposal)
2. **Explain how your preparation** makes you ready to conduct such research (research experience, coursework,...)
3. **Explain why** you could be a good fit (for the school/profession) → tailoring the last paragraph to the school could be good but it is still debated whether the cost is worth it

Other good practice:

- **Get feedback early** from faculty, PhD students (LEAP mentor!), and peers. Also ask them for their SOP.
- **Cut, Cut and Cut more:** you will want to say a LOT, but admission committee's time is *very* limited
- **Useful resources:** Chris Blattman's blog, Konstantin Poensgen's page (has many very useful sources)

Statement of purpose: DON'Ts

1. **Write your CV in prose:** once again, very limited time from the committee, so you don't want to repeat information
2. **List professor's you'd like to work with.** This is tempting, and opinions vary, but I don't think the cost is worth the effort. At most mention a specific field/research center
3. **Write your life story**. Unless you have incredible narrative skills, it is hard to make a case for a very personal statement

Diversity statement: show how you contribute

- Choose one or two experiences that shaped your perspective
- Be specific about what you learned or did
- Connect this to how you will support the academic community
- Treat diversity broadly: background, access, mentoring, service, or perspective

500 words (more or less)

One clear example is stronger than a catalogue of claims.

Writing sample: make your research ability visible

1. **Use an existing paper** if it represents your best work - often master's thesis
2. **Make your contribution clear**, especially if the work is co-authored (some schools require the WS to be solo-authored)
3. **Work on the abstract/intro**: question, contribution, method, and main result
4. **Polish the details**: figures, tables, citations, and notation. People will at most skim through it
5. **Check every page limit** and prepare versions you can shorten cleanly (see more below)

No suitable paper yet? A focused research proposal can be the fallback.

CV

Lead with

- Education
- Research experience
- Thesis and research projects
- Relevant awards and fellowships

Then add

- Teaching and service
- Technical and language skills
- Presentations or publications, if any
- Consistent dates and clear links

LSE research statement: five questions, five signals

1. **Why economics research?**
   Motivation and broad interests
2. **Why are you prepared?**
   Technical background, research experience, and original work
3. **What will you like and dislike?**
   Realistic expectations, resilience, and self-reliance
4. **What is your favourite paper?**
   Summarise it; explain its contribution; identify a limitation and a credible improvement
5. **Can you write for a general audience?**
   Explain the economics, use evidence, and show the other side

The favourite-paper question is the key test of critical thinking.

If needed I can share the slides they gave us in a similar PhD workshop, just contact me.

October: turn drafts into applications

Share materials with everyone who is willing to read it (SOP, school list, CV,...)

- Share it with your **PI first**
- Ask faculty, your PhD mentor, PhD students, and friends
- Use different readers for structure, clarity, and credibility
- Expect to rebuild parts of the statement several times

Open the portals

- Check every prompt and required upload
- Confirm deadlines, fees, and word limits
- Invite your recommenders
- Record anything program-specific

October: make use of your LEAP Mentor!!!

- All of us signed up because we are happy to help: please make the most of it!
- Be proactive in contacting your mentor: you can then set up a timeline for mentoring together
- Don't be afraid to go back-and-forth: we can set the limit if it's too much
- The earlier you contact us/send us something, the more we can do. But we *should not* be a source of additional stress

October: build one application tracker

One row per program; one column per requirement.

School	Program	Deadline	GRE	GRE Fees	Fee	Letters	Writing Sample	WS Length	Diversity Statement	DS Length	GRE Code
Stanford	Econ	29-Nov	Yes	35	125	3	Yes	<10	Yes	500	4704
Stanford GSB	PolEcon	1-Dec	Yes	35	125	3	No		Yes	500	4704
Harvard	Econ	1-Dec	Yes	35	105	3	Yes	>15	Yes ("personal statement")	500	3451
Harvard HBS	BusEcon	1-Dec	Yes	35	105	3	Yes	<10	Yes ("personal statement")	500	3451
Harvard HKS	PubPol	1-Dec	Yes	35	105	3	Yes	<20	Yes ("personal statement")	500	3451
Michigan	Econ	1-Dec	No	0	90	3	No		Yes	500	
Yale	Econ	1-Dec	Yes	35	105	3	Optional?		Yes ("personal narrative")	300	3987
Berkeley	Econ	4-Dec	Optional	35	135	3	Optional	any	Yes	NA	4833
UW Madison	Econ	5-Dec	Yes	35	75	3	Yes	any	Yes	600	1846
Chicago	Econ	5-Dec	Yes	35	90	3	Yes	20-30	No?		1832
Chicago Harris	PubPol	6-Dec	Yes	35	90	3	Yes	20-30	No		1832
Columbia	Econ	14-Dec	Yes	35	120	3	Yes	<30	Yes	1000	2162
MIT	Econ	15-Dec	Optional	35	75	3	Optional	? Maybe just cv	No		3514
Chicago Booth	Econ	15-Dec	Yes	35	80	3	Optional	any	No		1501
LSE	Econ	15-Dec	Yes	35	100	2	Optional	any	No		0972

Track deadlines, fees, letters, tests, writing samples, statements, and submission codes.

Illustrative structure only: verify current requirements in each program's portal.

November: prepare multiple versions

Requirements vary

- Different SOP word limits
- Different writing-sample page limits
- Sometimes 2–5 versions of the same document

Prepare systematically

- Keep one master version
- Label files by document and limit
- Shorten sections without breaking the narrative
- AI tools can help, but restructuring still takes time

November: apply for fee waivers early

Dear Madam/Sir,

I am currently a pre-doctoral fellow at SIEPR, in California.

Application fees and grad school application in general are really expensive, especially when one applies to more than 20 schools. As a pre-doctoral fellow at Stanford, the stipend allows me to live in California, but life is extremely expensive in the Bay Area, which is why I am applying for fee waivers.

Additionally, a lot of schools do not offer fee waivers to international students (if not already part of the institution or permanent US resident. Fee waivers, test score prices + sending official GRE/IELTS scores can sum up to more than 3000$ according to my calculations. I would hence very much appreciate having access to such a fee waiver.

Best,

Raphaël Boulat

Example of a short fee-waiver request.

- I received waivers from **Yale, Princeton, and three Harvard programs**
- Chicago, Berkeley, LSE, and other schools also accept fee-waiver applications
- Apply as early as possible: some programs have a fixed number
- Check the process and eligibility on each program's website

November/December: track every letter

1. Add a status for every program: **invited / opened / submitted**
2. Check the application portal; do not rely only on email notifications
3. Send one consolidated reminder before the earliest outstanding deadline
4. Include the program, deadline, and submission link in the reminder
5. Update your tracker as soon as each letter arrives

Once the letters are uploaded and materials are ready: send, send, send!

It is a stressful period but it was a rewarding moment for me

Winter - Timeline & Waitlist

- Results start coming at the beginning of February up to April (or even later for some European places)
- Waitlists
  - If you are on a waitlist that you want to get off of you need to tell them that you will attend if admitted and express interest; it won't just happen
  - Be proactive in letting your PI know about your results, and waitlists in particular! They can work behind the scenes to help you succeed, but they need to know your options and your preferences
  - If you win a fellowship that comes with a lot of funding, reach out to all dominating programs that have rejected or waitlisted you telling them this (some might ignore it but doesn't matter)
- Go to any visit day you are invited too, especially if you are on the waitlist

Once the letters are uploaded and materials are ready: send, send, send!

It is a stressful period but it was a rewarding moment for me

Winter - ”Apps Decorum”, A (not so) Personal Take

- This is an extremely stressful process, but you can work together to make it a bit better for each other

  → Avoid asking people direct apps related questions unless you have agreed it is okay to do so. You probably mean well, but these questions can cause unnecessary stress

  → Also kindly avoid talking about apps results in public spaces at the office

- Whenever you get a dominant offer, please withdraw asap from dominated programs (of course this does not mean you should rush your decision). This is where the bucket design comes handy

Mental Health

- This is an extremely noisy process, and your results do NOT define you either way
- Having friends outside of academia/the process can be super useful (but easier said than done)
- Do not hesitate/feel ashamed to seek help - Bocconi Counseling, options outside of university
- Try avoiding forums where people share results (He-Who-Must-Not-Be-Named)

Questions?

You can always email them to me as well: raphael.boulat@phd.unibocconi.it